alike. Among the detractors were luminaries like the founder of Sikhism, Guru Nanak, who despaired that due to the coming of the Mughals, the Muslims were losing their ‘five-time prayers’ and the Hindus their ‘hours of worship’, and Babur would need to overcome that resistance.

The Afghans of the Lodi dynasty, meanwhile, melted into the countryside and removed themselves to Bihar and Bengal, where we will encounter them time and again, as they resisted integration into the upstart Mughal Empire. Over the next four years, Babur consolidated his fledgling empire and extended it ‘in a strip of territory stretching from eastern Afghanistan through central Punjab to the mid-Gangetic plain’. Scholars have shown that Babur may also have begun to centralize political and administrative authority at this point by separating a nobleman’s personal income from the revenue he was assigned for the disbursing of salaries to retainers. He also divided his territories into two parts—khalisa, or crown lands, and jagirs*. Two-thirds of the land under cultivation was divided between Babur’s military generals, who deposited a fixed amount of money as land revenue into the state treasury.

To create a Timurid homeland, Babur sent messages to displaced Timurid descendants who had been set adrift by the rise of the Uzbeks, inviting them to be part of his court. According to his daughter Gulbadan, Babur sent ‘letters in all directions, urgently saying, “We shall take into full favour all who enter our service and especially such as served our father and grandfather and ancestors… Whoever there may be of the families of Sahib-Qiran (Timur) and Chingiz Khan, let them turn towards our court.”’ Ninety-six Timurid women answered this call, in addition to the noblemen, and a glimmer of Timurid culture was founded at Agra.

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There was a great deal that Babur would find alien in Hindustan, even more so when he compared it to what he felt he had lost in Ferghana. Yet Babur would write about this new land evocatively, showing an almost grim resolve to find solace in its stark beauty. For despite the dismaying lack of melons, good horses, elegant clothes, and tidy streams, Babur was canny enough to realize the vast resources that Hindustan had to offer. He noted with amazement the fertility of the soil of the Indo-Gangetic plains, which could produce two harvests a year. The most durable image of the countryside, today as it was more than 400 years ago, was the peasant in his fields, with his plough and oxen, an indistinct blur against the immensity of